

MSc Cyber Security at NIBM

— —
*with Postgraduate Diploma exit - a
franchise business case*

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September 2026 - 15 minutes

MSc Cyber Security

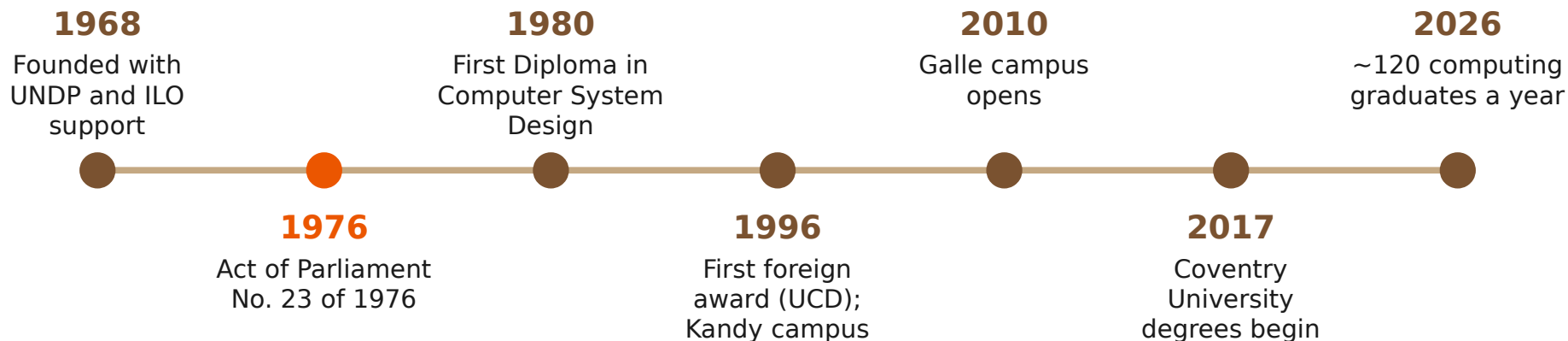
PgDip exit award

Taught at NIBM Colombo

*Essex award - Essex standards -
NIBM delivery*

A statutory institution since 1976

Created by statute, accountable to a ministry, running foreign university awards for thirty years. The claim is permanence, not age.



State-owned institute under the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Skills Development. Regional campuses: Colombo (1968), Kurunegala (1986), Kandy (1996), Galle (2010), Matara; two innovation centres with Limkokwing University.

Thirty years of delivering external awards

Every degree NIBM delivers today already runs under an external awarding body's quality oversight. A franchise is a familiar operating model, not a new one.

Academic awards and pathways

Coventry University (UK)

Undergraduate degrees at NIBM since 2017, including BSc (Hons) Ethical Hacking and Network Security

University College Dublin (Ireland)

First foreign award at NIBM: BSc Management Information Systems, 1996

Griffith University (Australia)

Transfer pathway for NIBM students

Ural Federal; Limkokwing University

Engineering links; two creative-technology innovation centres

Industry academies and centres

Cisco and Red Hat academies

Network and systems curricula delivered to vendor standard

AWS Academy; EC-Council partnership

Cloud and security curricula, the base for cloud-hosted lab ranges

Microsoft; Oracle

Platform partnerships supporting software and data teaching

BCS accredited training provider

Accredited provider for BCS Agile and Business Analysis certifications in Sri Lanka

Why Essex: top of the Colombo field

Awarding university	Via	CUG	Guardian	NCSC status, UK programme
University of Essex	NIBM (proposed)	29	12	Provisional, to Sep 2027
Lancashire (formerly UCLan)	UCL Sri Lanka	86	98	Not listed
Kingston	ESOFT	89	55	Full, expires 30 Sep 2026
Staffordshire	APIIT	94	82	Not listed
Westminster	IIT	123	122	Full, to Sep 2028

UK awards delivered via Sri Lankan partners; 2026 league tables; NCSC status of the UK-delivered programme (May 2026 list). Franchise scope: for Essex to confirm.

6th

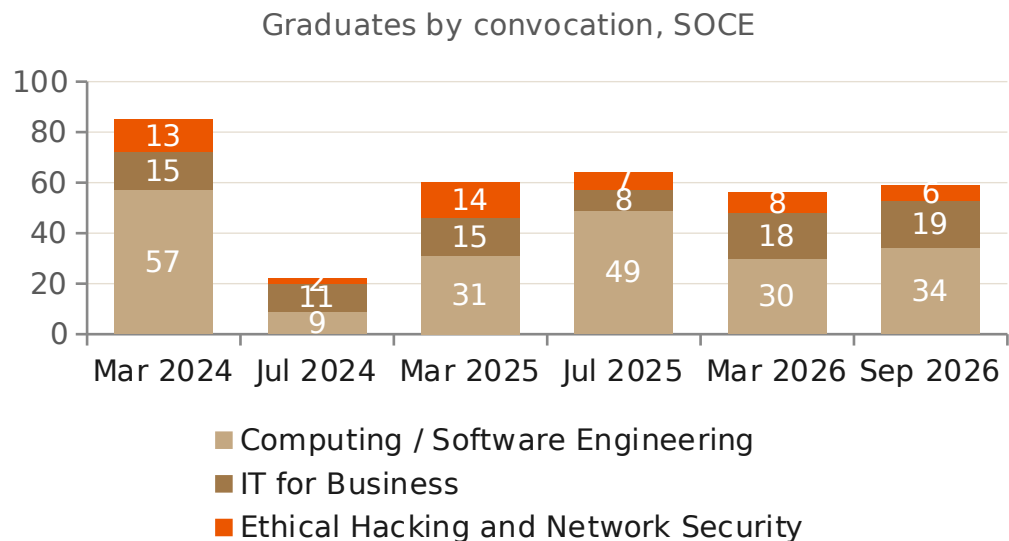
UK research power in computer science (THE, REF 2021)

120

credit PgDip exit in Essex's own award portfolio

Campus MSc profile: security by design, digital identity, digital forensics, network security. The natural continuation of NIBM's Ethical Hacking and Network Security stream.

One computing base, and no rung above Level 6



Yearly totals 107 (2024), 124 (2025), 115 (2026). 346 graduates in the last six convocations, none with a postgraduate route at NIBM.

~120

**computing
graduates a year
across three
programmes**

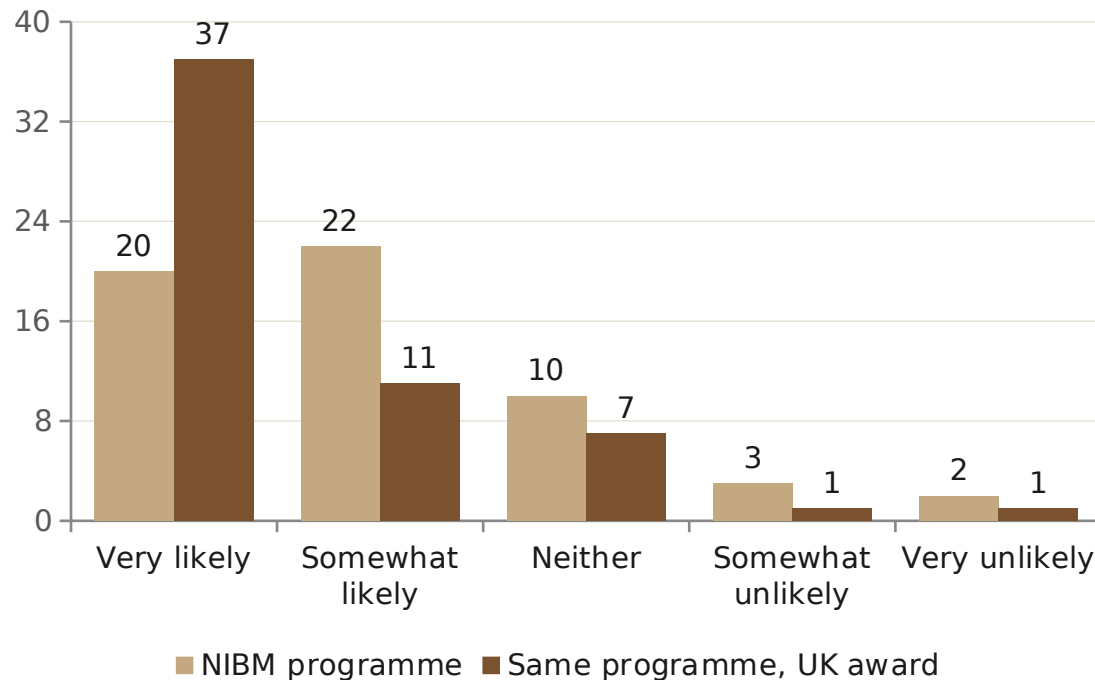
**17 to
51**

**year-3 entries per
intake to the cyber
stream, Nov 2024 to
Nov 2025; Nov 2026
expected above 25**

0

**postgraduate cyber
places at NIBM
today**

Demand rises with a UK award



74% to 84%

likely or very likely to enrol,
before and after the UK award

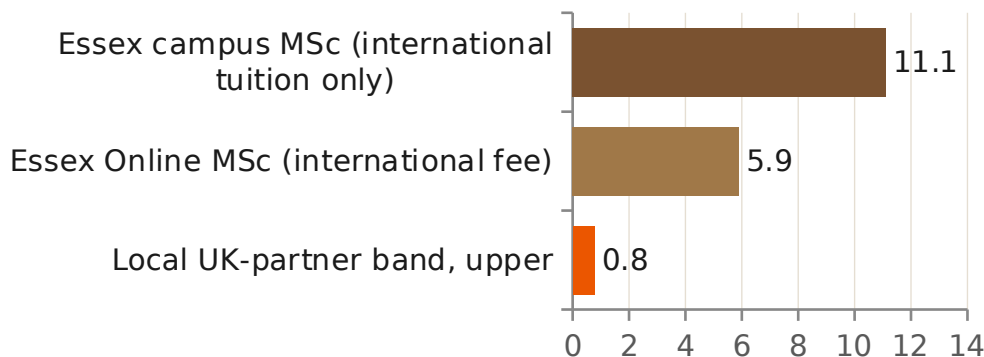
23 up, 0 down

respondents who changed
their answer on hearing the
award is UK-issued

n = 57, self-selected internal
sample, Sep 2026; price untested.
Raised on GCE O/L and A/L,
Edexcel and Cambridge, this
market knows UK awards.

The affordability corridor

Cost of a UK Cyber Security MSc to a Sri Lankan student, LKR millions



GBP 24,675 and GBP 13,049 at about LKR 450 per pound (August 2026). Local band LKR 0.35 to 0.78 million from the NIBM competitor matrix; four of six local UK-partner routes publish no

Sterling bought about 264 rupees at the 2022 low and about 450 today: the same UK fee costs a Sri Lankan family roughly 70% more rupees than four years ago.

Why the corridor matters now

- Entry-level IT pay starts near LKR 80,000 a month; the online Essex MSc equals about six years of it.
- SLASSCOM: about 17,000 IT graduates a year; entry-level supply is no longer the bottleneck.
- AI is compressing generalist roles: IFS cut 400 to 450 Sri Lankan staff from Nov 2025, citing AI.
- The rational response is to specialise. A UK Masters priced locally is the only route within reach, a segment neither Essex product serves.

Committed demand, discounted in the open

57 responded

41 positive on a UK award and able to start within 12 months

29 central weighting (0.8 / 0.3)

21 conservative weighting (0.6 / 0.2)

Per intake, by entry lane

Survey rates: 37.5% conservative, 50% central (21 and 29 of 57).

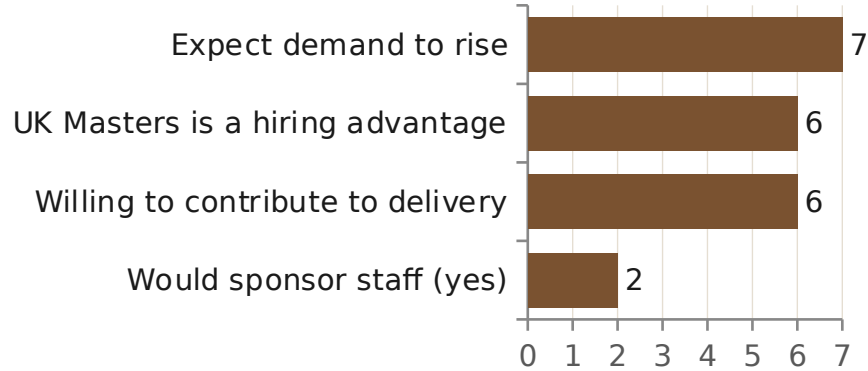
Direct lane, ~20 cyber graduates a year today: 7 to 10

Bridged lane, ~100 other computing graduates, rate halved for bridge friction: 19 to 25

Together: 26 to 35 per intake

Not counted: 346 recent alumni, working professionals, and the direct lane doubling from 2027. Public benchmark: UCSC's state-sector Master of Cybersecurity took 28 in its 2023 intake.

Industry describes a postgraduate gap



Sponsorship: 2 yes, 4 maybe, 0 no, 1 not applicable.
Contribution: 6 yes, 1 maybe. n = 7 senior respondents, none NIBM staff: IT services, telecom, insurance and its regulator, three national-university academics.

"Graduates may identify vulnerabilities but struggle to validate findings, prioritise business risks, and recommend fixes that account for availability, cost, and operational constraints." - IT services practitioner

What industry asked for	Essex MSc profile
Digital forensics; incident response	Forensics core; IR to map to modules
Network security in production	Core to the campus MSc
Application and API security	Security by design; extend locally
Cloud security and architecture	Local option or capstone
GRC as enterprise risk	Local option or capstone
Employer-reviewed capstone	Dissertation and capstone

The panel already teaching the stream below

Proposed panel, subject to availability and approval

Assoc. Prof. Manjula Sandirigama

Peradeniya; secure protocols; Attorney-at-Law. Leads Cybersecurity II and Research Project Delivery.

Dr Krishanthmohan Ratnam

Sri Jayewardenepura; survivable network design. Leads Networked Systems and Advanced Network Systems.

Industry practitioners and further academics

IT services, telecom, insurance and its regulator. Four industry and two further academic volunteers so far.

NIBM cyber faculty

Programme coordination, quality processes, assessment administration, student support.

Structure and entry

- MSc 180 credits, PgDip exit at 120; evening and weekend delivery
- Employer-reviewed capstone; supervision from the university panel
- Direct entry: network and cyber graduates
- Bridged entry for other computing graduates, subject to Essex approval: professional qualification plus experience, or a priced NIBM bridge

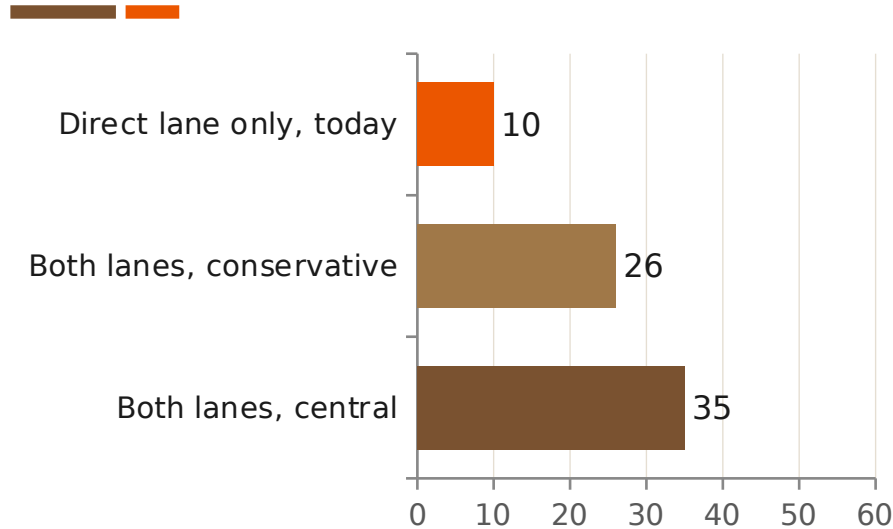
Laboratories

- Offensive labs on BYOD; defensive, cloud and forensic labs on cloud-hosted ranges
- AWS Academy, EC-Council partnership; dedicated facility requested

Risks we would rather name first

Risk	Evidence today	Mitigation	Owner
Price untested	No fee question; 40% would need a loan or scholarship	Fee-band question before any forecast; explore employer sponsorship (2 yes, 4 maybe)	NIBM
Staff approval	Panel delivers the UG stream; Essex approves each teacher by name	CV pack for every module leader and supervisor, ready on request	NIBM, Essex
No dedicated facility yet	BYOD and cloud labs; physical facility requested, pending	Cloud-first launch; physical lab as phase two	NIBM
Essex Online overlap	Online MSc sold into Sri Lanka at about LKR 5.9 million	Different segment: locally priced cohort with labs; buyers who cannot reach the online fee	Joint
NCSC scope	Campus MSc provisionally certified to Sep 2027; franchise scope unknown	Confirm what may be claimed locally; no claim until confirmed	Essex
Bridge cost and criteria	ISC2 free CC route closed May 2026; criteria are Essex's to approve	Lane two priced by NIBM; lane one criteria proposed for Essex approval	NIBM, Essex

Scale, and what we ask



Indicative places per intake at NIBM Colombo; alumni, professionals, the growing direct lane and regional campuses not counted; not price-tested. No local route today combines a UK award, certification standing, supervised labs and an evening-and-weekend timetable.

What we ask of Essex

1. Agreement in principle to scope a franchise of the MSc with PgDip exit
2. Exchange of due-diligence packs: our evidence repository for your partner requirements
3. A joint scoping visit to Colombo within the next quarter

Sources and methods

Survey A, students and graduates	Microsoft Forms, 6 items, anonymous, fielded 22 to 23 Sep 2026 within NIBM, n = 57. Convenience sample, no population denominator, no fee question. 86% current undergraduates. Purchase-intent weighting stated on each figure.
Survey B, industry and external academics	Microsoft Forms, 9 items, named, fielded 22 to 23 Sep 2026, n = 7. Purposive sample of senior practitioners and academics already engaged with NIBM. Qualitative evidence; quoted by sector only, pending attribution consent.
NIBM institutional facts	NIBM Law No. 23 of 1976; SOCE website (soce.nibm.ac.lk); SOCE convocation records Mar 2024 to Sep 2026 and year-3 intake records Nov 2024 to Nov 2026.
University of Essex	Partnerships framework ("Our approach to new partnerships"); MSc Cyber Security course page and fees; Essex Online award structure, fees and entry criteria; REF 2021 research power (THE measure).
Competitive landscape	NIBM competitor matrix, Sep 2026; NCSC certified degrees list (May 2026); Complete University Guide and Guardian league tables, 2026 editions.
Market and economy	GBP/LKR rates (OFX, Aug 2026); ITPro.lk salary guide 2026; Ceylon Today, 12 Apr 2026 (SLASSCOM graduate figures); The Examiner, 15 May 2026 (IFS layoffs); ISC2, 22 Apr 2026 (end of free CC programme).

Questions & Discussion

The evidence pack behind every figure is available to the Essex partnerships team on request.

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